03

PART 3 OF 9

Egypt, the Exodus and the Wilderness

EXOD, NUM, DEUT

From the grain fields of the Nile Delta, across the rocky paths of Sinai, to the threshold of the Promised Land.



The Road That Shaped a People

Imagine a world where water is life and the desert is the boundary. The Egypt of the Book of Exodus is the land of the Nile: each year the river floods and leaves fertile silt, and the delta becomes a mosaic of fields, canals and cities full of storehouses. Here, among the brickyards and granaries, lived the descendants of Jacob, ever more numerous and ever more burdened with forced labor. Exod 1–2 shows a state that needs hands to build, yet fears the very people who supply them. Geography and politics are intertwined from the first chapter.

Beyond the eastern border of the delta, a completely different world begins. The Sinai Peninsula is a triangle of desert, narrow wadis and granite massifs, where the daily struggle is for water and shade. The Exodus from Egypt is therefore not a simple journey but a passage between two orders: from an organized state to a place where everything must be received as a gift. The books of Exodus, Numbers and Deuteronomy describe this march in stages, naming dozens of stopping places. Some of them we know fairly well today; others remain puzzles for scholars.

In this atlas we follow the route step by step. For each place we give the coordinates of the traditional or most widely accepted identification, and where scholars disagree, we say so openly. This applies especially to the Sea of Reeds, Mount Sinai and many of the stops in the wilderness. The illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological and geographical knowledge, not photographs of the past. Distances and numbers are marked “approx.” because ancient sources do not give them with modern precision. In this way the map and the text will help you see how the shape of the land influences the course of the events described.

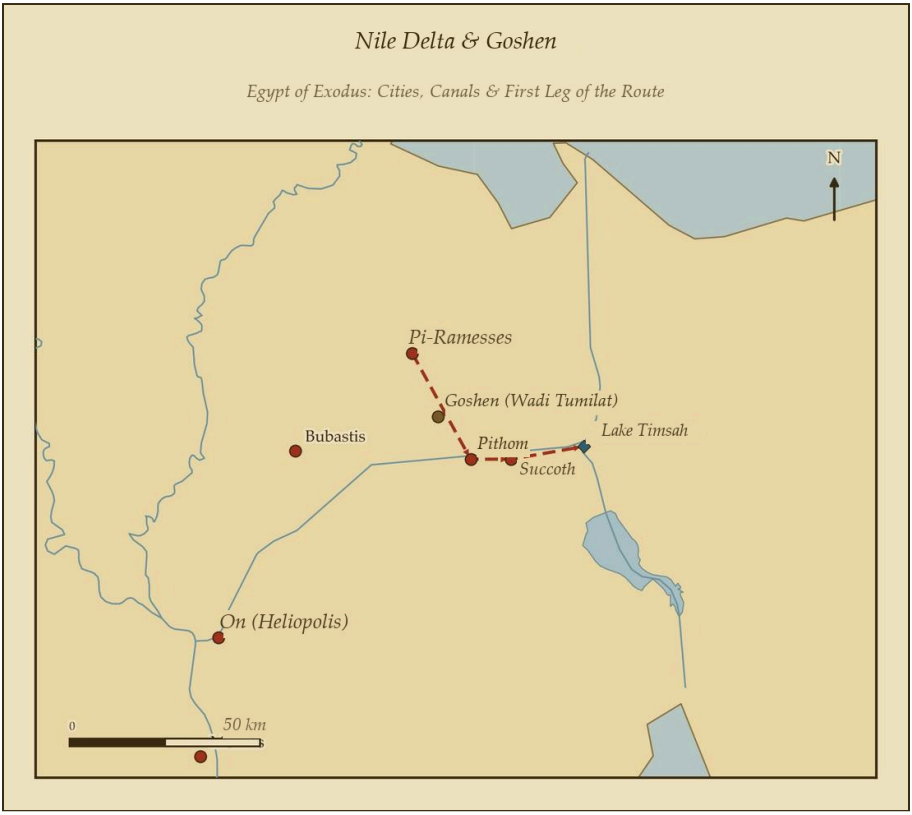
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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

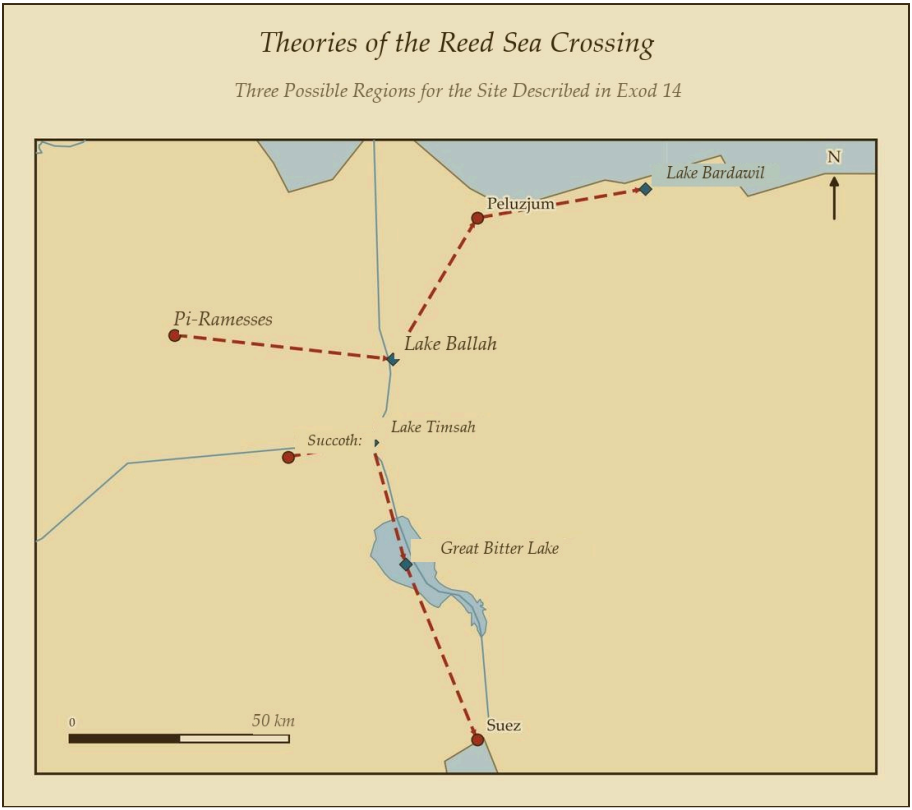
MAP 3.1



The dots mark cities and places mentioned in the Book of Exodus, and the line shows the probable beginning of the route. Many locations are debated.

The map shows the eastern part of the Nile Delta, the region where, according to Exod 1–12, the Israelites lived. Note the Wadi Tumilat, a narrow corridor leading from the Nile toward the Bitter Lakes. It is a natural route east, along which store cities and camps lay. The distances on the map are small, approx. 50 km between Pi-Rameses and Succoth, but for a group with children and flocks they meant several days of walking.

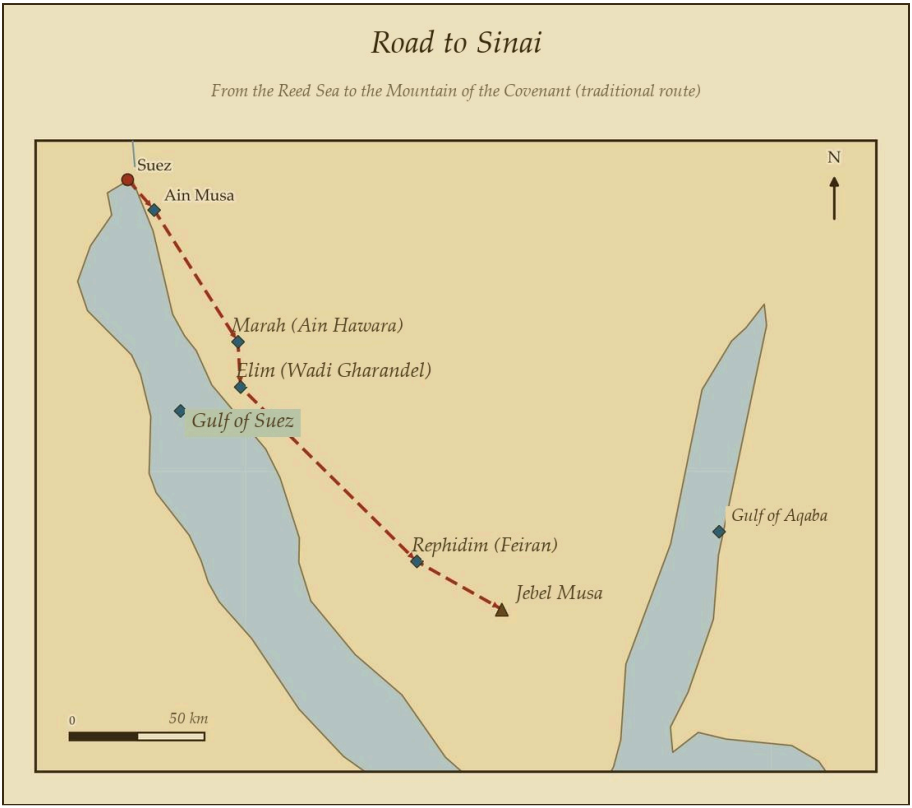
MAP 3.2



The two lines show alternative route proposals by scholars, not an established course of events. The waters are marked approximately.

This map sorts out the main hypotheses about the Sea of Reeds. The northern route leads toward the lakes near the Mediterranean coast, the central one through the area of Lake Timsah and the Bitter Lakes, and the southern one toward the Gulf of Suez. Since ancient times the water level and the shape of the coastline have changed, so today's map does not show that landscape exactly. The most important thing is to understand that the dispute concerns the location, not the message of the story.

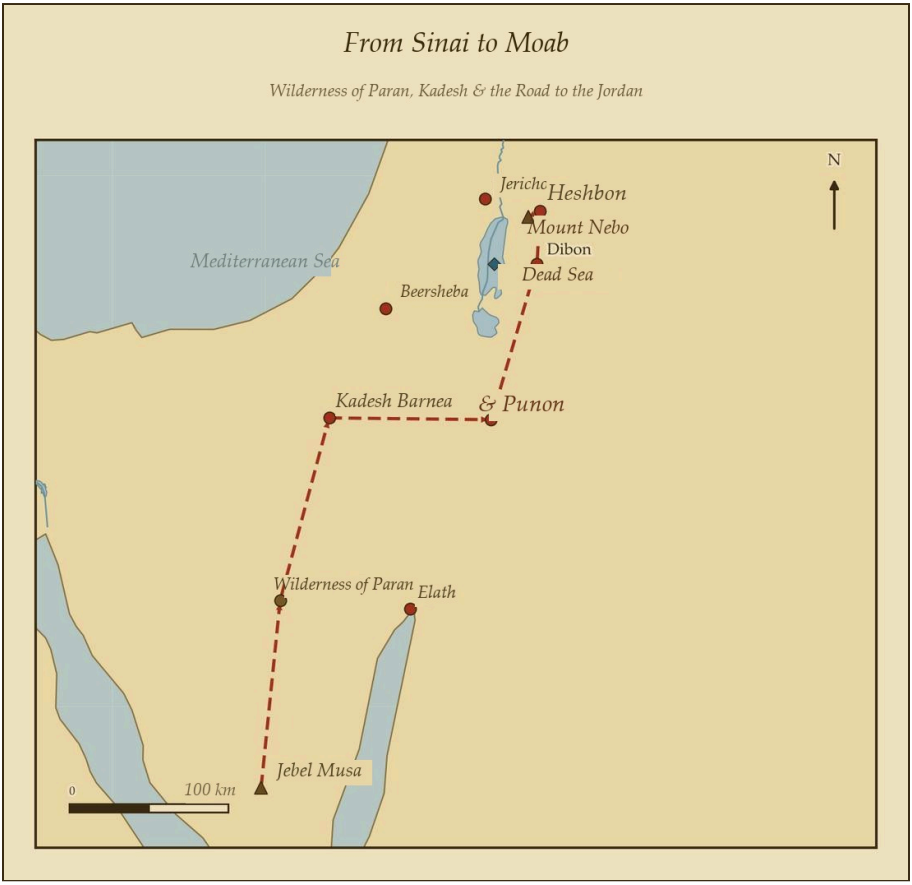
MAP 3.3



The line shows the traditional route through southern Sinai, from Suez to Jebel Musa. Alternative locations of Sinai would mean a different course.

The map shows how the road leads from oasis to oasis: from the bitter water at Marah, through the palms at Elim, to Feiran at the foot of the mountains. The terrain gradually rises, and the landscape changes from flat to mountainous. Jebel Musa is approx. 2,285 m above sea level. Remember that this is only one hypothesis: some scholars look for Sinai in the north of the peninsula or in Arabia.

MAP 3.4



The first line leads from Sinai through Paran to Kadesh, the second from Kadesh along Edom and Moab to Mount Nebo. The routes are approximate.

The map shows the final stages of the journey. From Kadesh the people did not go straight into the land, but turned east, going around Edom and Moab (Num 20–21). The text names many stops that we cannot identify with certainty, so the route is simplified. Note how close Nebo and Jericho are: about 25 km apart in a straight line, with the Jordan Valley between them.

01 Pi-Rameses, the City of Rameses

EXOD 1; 12

The great capital of the delta, where the Israelites worked building storehouses and cities.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

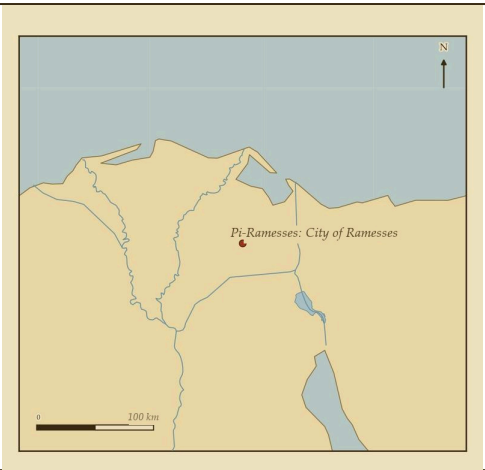
Imagine a wide, flat plain dotted with fields and canals. On the horizon rise temple gates faced with pale stone, and below them long rows of clay storehouses. Barges of acacia wood are moored at the quay. The air is hot and smells of silt and bakery smoke. All of this is an artistic reconstruction, based on finds from Qantir and Tell el-Daba, not an exact plan of the city.

Exod 1:11 says that the Israelites built supply cities for Pharaoh, Pithom and Rameses. The work with brick, clay and fields was hard, and the ruler feared that the growing people would become a threat on the eastern border. Exod 12 describes the night when, after dramatic events, Pharaoh let the people go. The text stresses haste: unleavened bread, traveling clothes, families gathered together. The Exodus therefore begins not in the silence of the desert, but in the midst of a crowded administrative capital.

Pi-Rameses lay on the eastern edge of the delta, near a former branch of the Nile, which gave the city a port and access to trade routes to Sinai and Canaan. The area of present-day Qantir is most often accepted as the site, though some scholars point to nearby Tell el-Daba. It is thus a dispute over location, not over the existence of the city in the time of Rameses II. The nearness of the border explains why the army, workshops and storehouses were built right here. From here the routes to the desert were counted in days, not weeks. Think of the scale of such a metropolis: numerous temples, craftsmen's quarters, stables for horses and canals along which barges brought stone and grain. In such a place the violence of the daily labor system was visible at every step, but just as visible was the power that the biblical story stands against. That is why Exod 12 ends with the image of families setting out at dawn.

FACTS

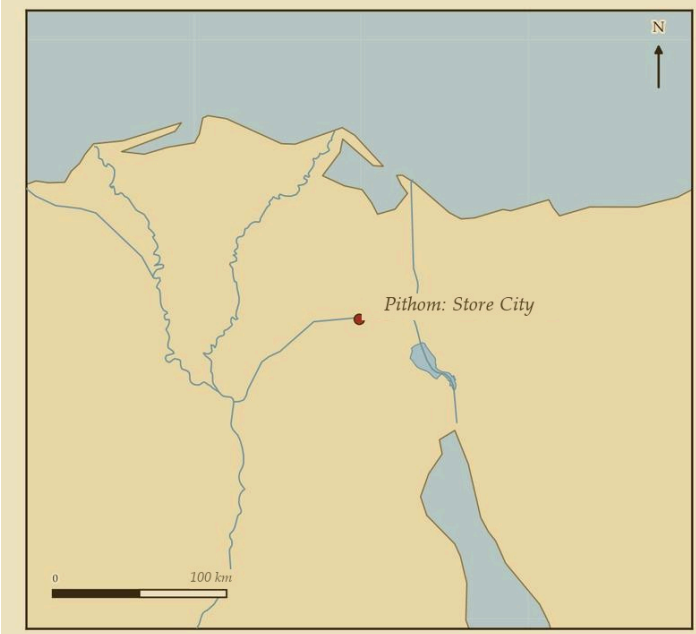
The distance from Pi-Rameses to Lake Timsah is approx. 50 km in a straight line (the city's location is debated: Qantir or Tell el-Daba).


N
Pi-Ramesses: City of Ramesses
0
100 km

02 Pithom, the Store City

EXOD 1:11

The second of the store cities, built in the narrow valley of the Wadi Tumilat.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a row of long, low storehouses of raw brick, arranged around a rectangular courtyard. Beside them rises a small temple with columns, and by the canal people are working, kneading clay with straw. Donkeys with sacks of grain stand beneath the walls. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on finds from the store cities of the delta, not a portrait of a particular excavation.

3.2 · PITHOM, THE STORE CITY · EXOD 1:11

Exod 1:11 names Pithom as one of two cities that the Israelites built as supply centers. The name Pithom comes from an Egyptian name meaning the house of the god Atum, which suggests a cultic center connected with storehouses. The text shows how forced labor was linked to the state economy: brick, clay and straw become the foundation of structures meant to secure power. The book gives no details of the architecture, but the very mention of supplies shows that the delta was also a logistical base for military expeditions.

It is most commonly assumed that Pithom lay in the Wadi Tumilat, a narrow valley running from the Nile east toward the Bitter Lakes. Tell el-Retaba is regarded as a candidate, though some scholars choose Tell el-Maskhuta, so the location is debated. The valley was a natural corridor: it had water, pastures and roads along which caravans and armies moved. That is why cities with supplies were placed there, and later one of the possible escape routes toward the desert ran this way. Geography thus explains why the story concentrates on this strip of land. For the reader, the difference in scale between the two places matters: Pi-Rameses was a great capital, Pithom rather a logistical center. Together they form a picture of a land in which work on resources was organized on a vast scale. Looking at the map, you see both cities about 40 km apart, on a single route leading to the border.

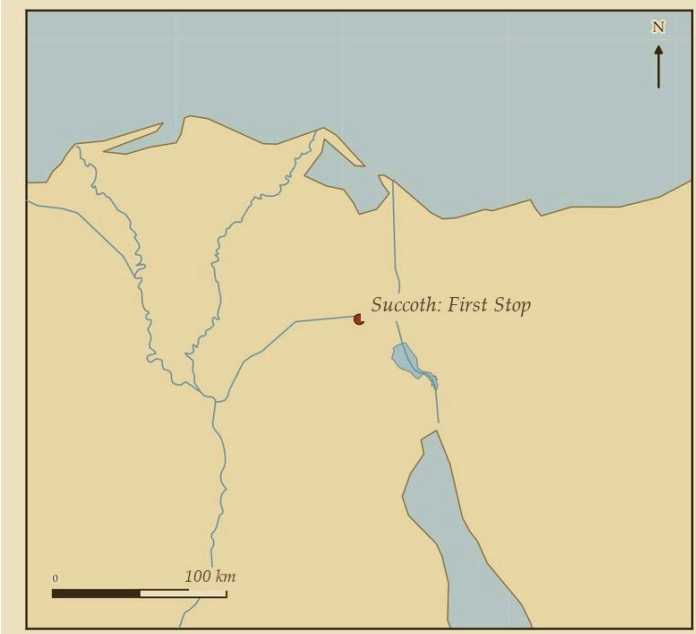
FACTS

The Wadi Tumilat is approx. 50 km long; the location of Pithom (Tell el-Retaba or Tell el-Maskhuta) is debated.

03 Succoth, the First Stop

EXOD 12:37; 13:20

The first camp of the refugees, at the edge of the desert.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a broad strip of sand and low shrubs at the edge of the valley. Along a narrow canal, makeshift huts of branches and cloth have been set up, and sheep graze nearby. Smoke from the campfires rises straight up, because there is no wind. In the distance the first rocky hills can be seen. This is an artistic reconstruction, not an exact picture of a particular place.

Exod 12:37 says that the Israelites set out from Rameses to Succoth, with many men, women, children and large flocks. The text also speaks of a mixed crowd that joined them. Exod 13:20 adds that the next stop was Etham, on the edge of the wilderness. Succoth means “booths,” and it captures the character of the place well: makeshift shelters where people stop for the first night. The story slows down here and shows weariness, uncertainty and a community being born on the road.

Succoth is usually identified with the Egyptian Tjeku, that is, the area of Tell el-Maskhuta in the Wadi Tumilat, but the location is debated. The valley leads exactly toward the Bitter Lakes and Lake Timsah, so it is a natural first stage of the move east. The distance from Rameses is approx. 50 km in a straight line, which at the pace of a large group with children and cattle means several days of walking. The border of Egypt was not a line on a map but a belt of fortresses and wells, which one crossed with the permission of the guards. It is worth noting that the Book of Exodus does not choose the shortest road through the land of the Philistines (Exod 13:17), but directs the people toward the wilderness. The reason is practical: that road was a military route full of Egyptian outposts. The choice of route thus shows how strongly geography and politics shape the course of the events described.

FACTS

From Pi-Rameses to Succoth (Tell el-Maskhuta) is approx. 50 km in a straight line; the location is debated.

04 The Sea of Reeds

EXOD 14–15

The place of the crossing, whose exact location remains a subject of research.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

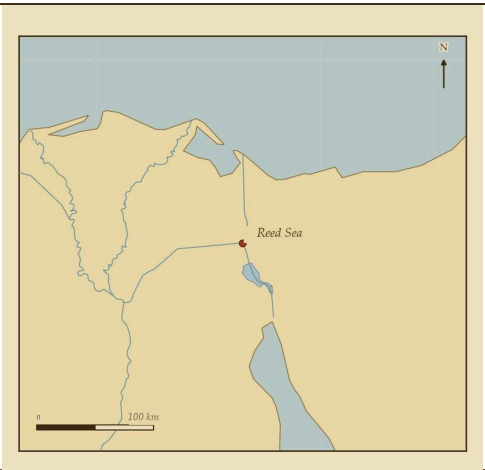
Imagine shallow water, cold at dawn, among dense thickets of reeds, vast as a lake, with no clear shore on the other side. The sky is gray and pink, and on the eastern side rises the low edge of the desert. On the shore, groups of people with animals can be seen from afar. This is an artistic reconstruction of one possible hypothesis, not an exact re-creation of the course of events.

Exod 14 tells of the camp by the water, of the pursuit by Pharaoh's army and of the crossing, which the Israelites regarded as the work of God. The Hebrew name yam suph means "sea of reeds" or "sea of rushes," and the Greek tradition translated it as the Red Sea. Exod 15 is a hymn of thanksgiving after this event. The text gives no coordinates, so the reader must rely on the clues in the names: Pi-hahiroth, Migdol and Baal-zephon (Exod 14:2). Their location is uncertain.

Scholars have proposed several hypotheses. The northern route leads to the lakes near the Mediterranean, the central route to Lake Timsah and the Bitter Lakes, and the southern route to the Gulf of Suez. Each has its supporters and arguments, so in this atlas we give Lake Timsah as an approximate point, noting that the location is debated. In the Wadi Tumilat the terrain changes from fertile to marshy, with reeds and shallow pools that could have formed a natural obstacle for an army in chariots. For the reader the most important thing is what the text itself says: the road toward the wilderness led through a place where water blocked both escape and pursuit. Considering geographical hypotheses does not weaken the message, but lets us see a realistic backdrop. The width of the shallow pools, on the order of a few kilometers, and the seasonal changes in water level fit well with the picture of a place where wind, land and water are at work.

FACTS

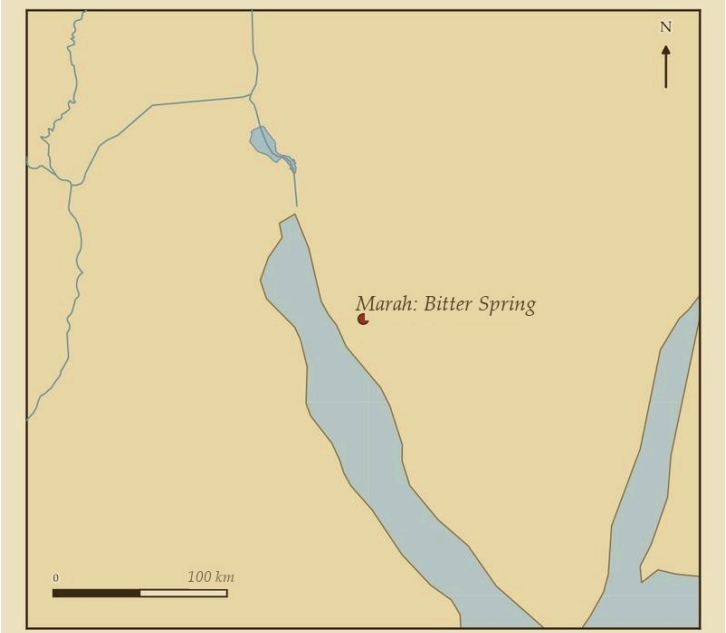
Three main route hypotheses (northern, central, southern) are considered for the crossing of the water; the distance from Succoth to Lake Timsah is approx. 20 km, and the location of the place is debated.


N
Reed Sea
0
100 km

05 Marah, the Bitter Spring

EXOD 15:22–26

The first water after three days of marching, but bitter to the taste.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a small, gravelly valley with a few tamarisk bushes. In a shallow hollow stands cloudy water with a white crust of salt. Stones heated by the sun lie all around, and in the background rises a pale limestone plateau. There is no shade here, so people shelter under sheets of cloth. This is an artistic reconstruction, not a photograph of a particular spring.

Exod 15:22–26 tells that after crossing the water the Israelites walked three days through the wilderness of Shur and found no water. When they reached Marah, the water proved undrinkable, so the people began to grumble. The story stresses how quickly the joy of deliverance gives way to weariness and fear for basic needs. Then the spring is healed, and the people receive instruction about listening to the voice of God. Marah becomes a symbol of the first trial in the wilderness.

Marah is traditionally identified with Ain Hawara, a spring of brackish water located approx. 80 km southeast of Suez. The location is debated, because some scholars prefer Ain Musa closer to Suez. The picture of a brackish spring fits the text well: on the eastern shore of the Gulf of Suez many waters are made saline by the limestone bedrock and the hot climate. Three days of marching at the average pace of a group with children and animals is about 40–60 km, which fits within this range. For reading the journey, it matters that water decides the route. In Sinai the paths lead from oasis to oasis, and between them stretch sections requiring days of marching without springs. Marah is the first such test, and Elim, the next place, shows the other side of the desert: wells and palms. The whole story thus has a rhythm of scarcity and abundance.

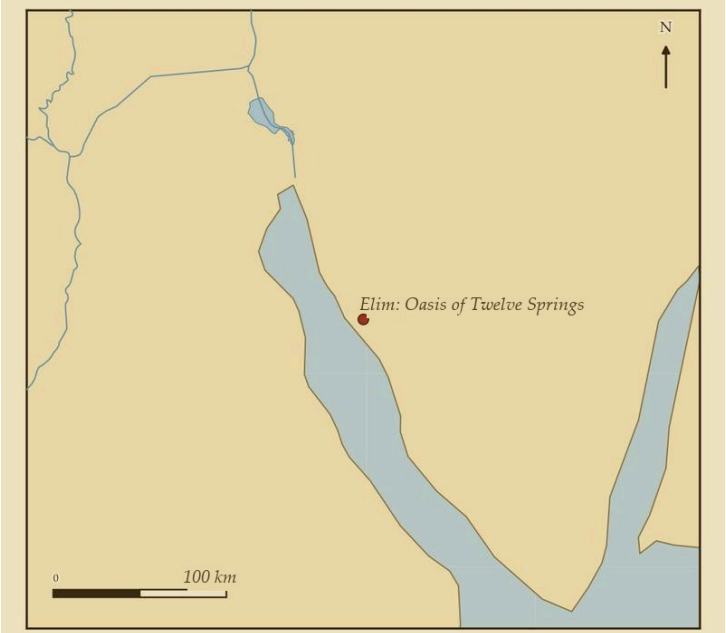
FACTS

Ain Hawara lies approx. 80 km southeast of Suez; the location of Marah is traditional and debated.

06 Elim, the Oasis of Twelve Springs

EXOD 15:27; NUM 33:9

A stop at twelve springs and seventy palm trees.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a narrow valley in which a green belt of palms and tamarisks grows from the stony floor. A stream flows beneath the tree crowns, and modest goat-hair tents stand beside it. Farther on, on the slopes of the wadi, sharp dark rocks stand out. The air here is noticeably cooler than in the open desert. This is an artistic reconstruction, not an exact re-creation of the oasis.

Exod 15:27 and Num 33:9 state that at Elim there were twelve springs and seventy palm trees, and that the people camped there by the water. Numbers in the Bible often have symbolic meaning, but here they describe the real richness of an oasis. After the bitter water at Marah, the text brings relief and the picture of a stable place of rest. The story does not develop the details, but the very brevity of the account suggests a moment of respite before further trials.

Elim is usually identified with Wadi Gharandel, a valley approx. 15–20 km south of Ain Hawara, though the location is debated. Wadi Gharandel has permanent water, tamarisks and date palms, so it fits the description well. In the Sinai region such oases are rare, and it is they that set the practical caravan routes. That is why scholars often look for stopping places near permanent springs, on the assumption that a group with cattle could not go long without water. The date palm was in the ancient world not only a source of shade but also of food: fruit, fibers for ropes and leaves for roofs. The picture of seventy palms thus describes a place where one can mend clothing, replenish supplies and rest. On the map you can see that Elim lies farther from Suez, toward the south of the peninsula, where the landscape begins to rise toward the granite massifs.

FACTS

Wadi Gharandel lies approx. 15–20 km south of Ain Hawara; the location of Elim is debated.

07 Rephidim, the Battle and Water from the Rock

EXOD 17

No water, a rock and the first battle in the wilderness.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

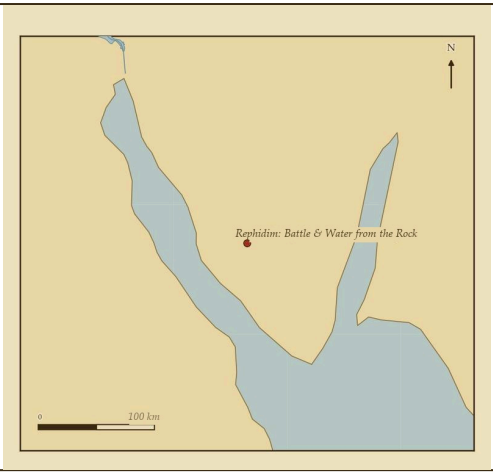
Imagine a wide, sunlit valley with a strip of green along a dry riverbed. Above it rise reddish-brown slopes with jagged ridges. In the distance, on a hill, two small figures support a third with raised hands, while below groups of people gather. This is an artistic reconstruction, not a literal picture of the text.

Exod 17 describes the camp at Rephidim, where there was no water and the people demanded help. Moses strikes the rock with his staff at God's direction, and water flows from the stone. The text calls the place Massah and Meribah, meaning "testing" and "quarrel." Right after this comes the attack of the Amalekites, a desert people. The story shows that a crisis on the road has many faces: thirst, conflict within the group and threat from outside.

Christian tradition has for centuries located Rephidim in the oasis of Feiran, in the Wadi Feiran, the largest oasis of southern Sinai. The location is debated, because Feiran lies approx. 25 km from Jebel Musa, which creates tension with the short interval of time described in the text. Feiran does, however, have palms, water and a strategic position on the route leading to the mountains. For a group wandering through the desert, taking such an oasis was a matter of survival, so an encounter with a local people is very likely. The battle with the Amalekites is fought in open terrain, in a narrow valley, where superior numbers do not always decide. Exod 17:11–12 describes Moses on the hill with raised hands, supported by Aaron and Hur. The image of the hill as a lookout point is tied to geography: high slopes above the wadi made it possible to see the whole battlefield. In this way nature and history once again intertwine in one place.

FACTS

The oasis of Feiran lies approx. 25 km from Jebel Musa in a straight line; the location of Rephidim is traditional and debated.


N
Rephidim: Battle & Water from the Rock
0
100 km

08 Sinai / Horeb (Jebel Musa)

EXOD 19–20; 24; 31–34

The mountain of the covenant, where the people received the Law.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

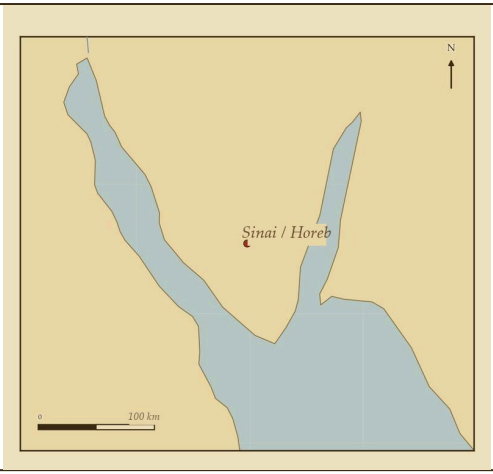
Imagine a huge, bare wall of red granite rising above a vast gravel valley. Dark clouds swirl over the summit, and below the campfires of the camp burn, scattered like points of light. There are no trees on the slopes, only rock and shadow. This is an artistic reconstruction, not an exact re-creation of the events.

Exod 19 says that three months after leaving Egypt the people stood at the foot of Mount Sinai. There follow preparation, thunder, fire and trumpets, and then the gift of the Decalogue (Exod 20). In the following chapters come the legal regulations, the making of the covenant (Exod 24), the episode of the golden calf and the instructions concerning the Tabernacle. The Book of Numbers (Num 1–10) adds the census of the people and the organization of the camp. The stay at the mountain lasts approx. a year and is the central point of the whole narrative.

Traditionally, Mount Sinai, also called Horeb, is identified with Jebel Musa (Mount Moses) in southern Sinai, at a height of approx. 2,285 m above sea level. This identification dates from Christian times and is tied to St. Catherine's Monastery at its foot. The location is debated: other peaks have also been proposed, including Jebel Serbal, and even places in Arabia or the Negev. Before the mountain stretches the flat plain of Er-Raha, where a large crowd could have camped. The granite mountain rises steeply above the valley and can be seen from afar, which explains the description of the boundaries set around it (Exod 19:12). The weather at this altitude can turn suddenly: storms with lightning, strong winds, cold nights even in summer. Such a landscape harmonizes well with the picture of a theophany in thunder and fire. When reading the text, however, remember that it is not geography but the encounter with God that is its heart.

FACTS

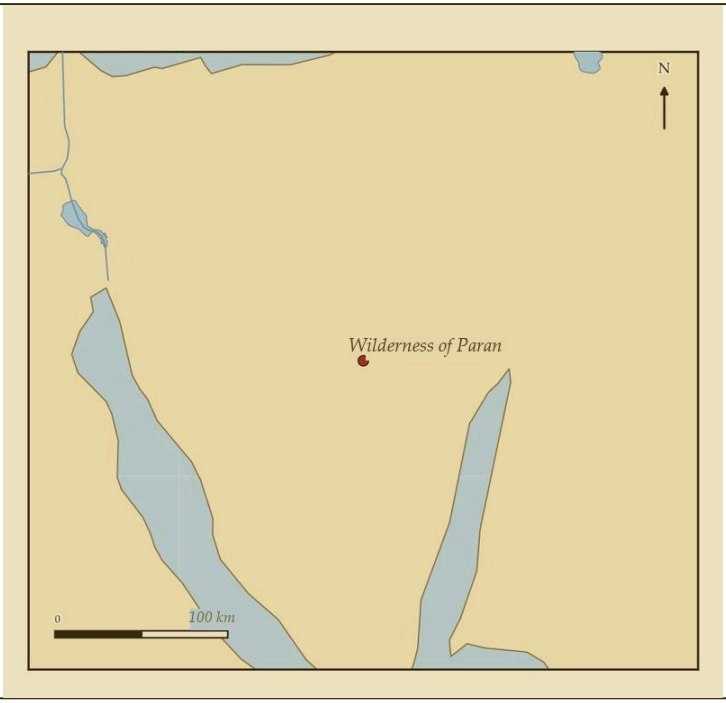
Jebel Musa is approx. 2,285 m above sea level; its identification with biblical Sinai is traditional and debated.


N
Sinai / Horeb
0
100 km

09 The Wilderness of Paran

NUM 10:12; 12:16; 13:3

A vast wilderness through which the people walked toward Kadesh.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine an endless, flat plateau covered with gravel and sparse clumps of shrubs. Here and there low, pale hills rise, and dry riverbeds stretch through the valleys. The air shimmers with heat, and on the horizon a thin line of a caravan can be seen. This is an artistic reconstruction, not a portrait of a particular place.

Num 10:12 says that after leaving Sinai the cloud came to rest in the wilderness of Paran. From here, according to Num 13:3, Moses sent twelve spies to explore the land of Canaan. The story shows a stage of successive stops, such as Taberah and Kibroth-hattaavah, where the people complained about food and their leaders (Num 11). Passing through this area took a long time and depended continually on water and fodder for the flocks.

The wilderness of Paran is a vast, harsh area in central Sinai and in the northern part of the peninsula, with rocky hills, plateaus and dry wadi beds. Its exact boundaries are not established, and the location of individual stops is debated. For the map we adopt a reference point in the central part, approx. 100–150 km from Jebel Musa. Routes connecting Sinai with the Negev ran through here, so the area was not completely cut off from the world. For the reader, it is important that Paran is not a single point but a region. The name denotes large spaces where people and flocks wandered from spring to spring. In the Bible this place also appears in the story of Hagar and Ishmael (Gen 21:21), which shows that it was a known zone for pastoral peoples. From the perspective of the narrative, Paran is the gate between the mountain of the covenant and the land of promise.

FACTS

The point on the map is approximate: the wilderness of Paran covers an area approx. 100–150 km across; its boundaries are debated.

10 Kadesh-barnea

NUM 13–14; 20:1–13

An oasis at the threshold of Canaan, where the people hesitated to enter.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

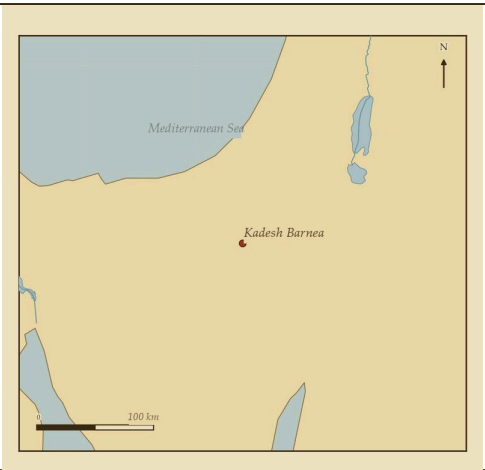
Imagine a green, spacious basin amid a dry, rocky desert. A spring forms several streams, along which shrubs and low trees grow. Numerous tents stand around the oasis, and on the hills traces of ancient paths can be seen. This is an artistic reconstruction, not an exact re-creation of the camp.

Num 13–14 tells of twelve spies who explored the land for forty days. They returned with fruit and descriptions of a fertile land, but most presented its inhabitants as too strong. The people began to complain and refused to enter, which the book interprets as a lack of trust. As a consequence, the generation that left Egypt was to remain in the wilderness, and the way into the land was postponed. Num 20:1–13 mentions the death of Miriam at Kadesh and a new conflict over water.

Kadesh-barnea is most often identified with the oasis of Ain el-Kudeirat in northern Sinai, approx. 80 km south of Beersheba. The location is debated, because Ain Qadis is also sometimes suggested. Ain el-Kudeirat is one of the largest springs in the region, surrounded by a fertile valley where cultivation is possible. The place lies at a crossroads of routes, so it provided the group with water and a good position, while also allowing a view of the roads leading to the Negev. From the oasis to Beersheba it is approx. 80 km in a straight line, which for families and flocks on the march would take several days. The oasis thus gives a picture of a place from which the goal can be seen, but a decision still has to be made. The book shows that the obstacle is not the distance itself but courage. That is why Kadesh-barnea remains in memory as the turning point of the whole journey.

FACTS

Ain el-Kudeirat lies approx. 80 km south of Beersheba; the location of Kadesh-barnea is debated.


N
Mediterranean Sea
Kadesh Barnea
0
100 km

11 The Plains of Moab

NUM 22–36; DEUT 1–4

The last camp before the Jordan, opposite Jericho.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a vast, hot lowland with shrubs, tamarisks and strips of green along the river. In the west the pale line of the Jordan and the palms of Jericho can be seen, and in the east the hills of Moab rise. Tents are pitched in rows, and white smoke from campfires rises above them. This is an artistic reconstruction, not an exact plan of the camp.

Num 22–36 describes the camp of the Israelites on the plains of Moab, on the east side of the Jordan, opposite Jericho. Here the episodes with Balaam take place, a new census of the people (Num 26) and the regulations concerning the division of the land. The Book of Deuteronomy, in turn, is a series of speeches by Moses, delivered in this very place. The story draws near its end, and the reader sees that the goal is not only to reach the land but also to prepare the people for life in it.

The plains of Moab are a wide strip of low terrain east of the Jordan, just by the Dead Sea, at an elevation below sea level. The exact location of the camp is debated, because the Bible gives names such as Shittim or Beth-peor, which we cannot identify with certainty. From the plains one can see Jericho and the palm valley of the Jordan in the west. The strip of land is several kilometers wide, which was enough for a temporary camp of a large community. The climate of the Jordan Valley is hot and dry in summer, and in spring the river floods, which, according to Josh 3:15, made crossing difficult. The location just before the border of the land makes Moab a symbolic place: the people are on the threshold, but not yet inside. Deut 1–4 recalls the whole journey and leads to the final instructions meant to shape the life of the community.

FACTS

The strip of the plains of Moab is several kilometers wide and lies below sea level; the point on the map is approximate, and the location of the camp is debated.

12 Mount Nebo

DEUT 32:48–52; 34

A view of the Promised Land and the end of Moses' journey.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

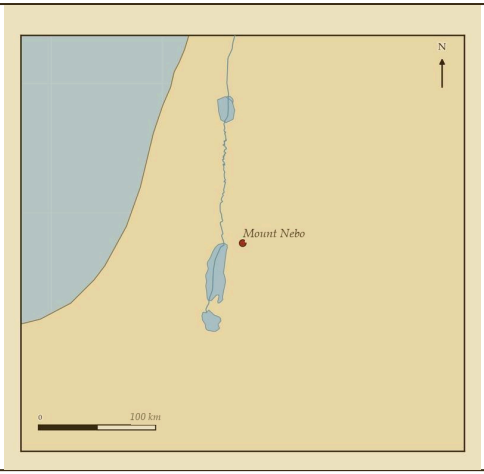
Imagine a broad, stony summit with low shrubs, from which one can see below the shining line of the Jordan and a vast yellow-brown lowland. Beyond it the gentle outlines of the mountains of Judea appear, and in the distance a band of blue water can be seen. On the summit a solitary figure stands far off, seen from behind. This is an artistic reconstruction, not an exact re-creation of the scene.

Deut 32:48–52 and Deut 34 present the last stage of Moses' life. At God's command he goes up Mount Nebo, the peak of Pisgah opposite Jericho, and from there surveys the broad land: Gilead, the Negev, the Jordan Valley, all the way to the distant hills. The text says that he did not enter the land, and that his grave remained unknown. The story ends with the memory of the people's mourning and the handing over of leadership to Joshua. This is the closing of the Pentateuch, full of gravity and gratitude.

Mount Nebo is traditionally identified with Ras Siyagha, a peak approx. 800 m above sea level, located in Jordan, approx. 10 km west of Madaba. The location is traditional rather than certain. From this point, in good weather, one can see the Jordan Valley, the northern part of the Dead Sea and the area around Jericho. The relative height above the valley exceeds 1,100 m, which gives a wide panorama while also clearly separating the observer from the land lying below. The significance of the geography is exceptional here: the place was chosen not by chance, but because it offers a view of the entire land of promise. From the reader's perspective, Nebo shows that the journey does not end in triumph, but in trust that the promise will be fulfilled in the next generation. Deut 34 also recalls that Moses was approx. 120 years old, and his strength did not leave him until the end.

FACTS

Ras Siyagha is approx. 800 m above sea level and rises over 1,100 m above the Jordan; its identification with Mount Nebo is traditional.


N
Mount Nebo
0
100 km

Questions for Reflection

1. Why, according to Exod 13:17, did the road lead through the wilderness and not along the shortest route by the coast, and what does this say about the role of geography in the story?

2. How does your reading of Exod 14 change when you know that the place of the crossing is debated and that scholars hold several hypotheses?

3. Which of the places on the journey, Marah, Elim, Rephidim, Kadesh or Nebo, best shows, in your opinion, the tension between scarcity and trust, and why?